Once its material rise has become indisputable, however, China has to deal with two major challenges, which come from opposite sources, to enhance its positive image and legitimacy in the world. On the one hand, China has to counter the prevalence of the "China threat" thesis. For the last few decades, it has devised multiple ways, ranging from its "charm offensive" toward smaller and/or neighboring powers to its announced doctrine of "peaceful rise," to soften its threating image perceived by others.[70] Here, BRICS has served China as a "prominent new club to shield its rise"[71] during the time of its emergence as a great power. Even now that China has already risen, the BRICS "shield" is still useful for legitimizing its benevolent leadership advocating (if not fully practicing) "democracy and equality (i.e., decentralization of power and more equal representation)" in the international system. Furthermore, it is useful for China to possess this benevolent image so that "balancing coalitions don't form to block" China's policy preferences.[72] On the other hand, China has relied on the BRICS group to overcome its capacity constraints.[73] Although China's financial expertise has strengthened rapidly, its presence and experience in global financial governance is yet to fully develop.[74] China very recently graduated from a net aid-recipient status.[75] China's economic globalization is quite recent, and its staff presence in international financial institutions is still relatively low.[76] In this context, sharing ideas and experiences with the BRICS experts and policymakers provides China with important learning opportunities.[77] In addition, coordinating with the BRICS regarding the discourse demanding international financial order effectively legitimizes its demands.[78] Hence, the BRICS collaboration provides China with the credential as the leading developing country that is serious about South-South cooperation.

It is not only in the face of the developing world that China has to enhance its legitimacy. The global market and its players have to see Chinese policies as legitimate, too. In short, for China to be successful in reforming the global financial architecture, the BRICS and its newly established institutions have to receive the seal of approval by the major market players. Although the Chinese government would use its financial resources for strategic purposes, it also needs to worry about its investments as a major creditor nation so the Chinese government has no intention of tarnishing its reputation and credibility in the global market by making the